Keeping House

Tiffany Wayne



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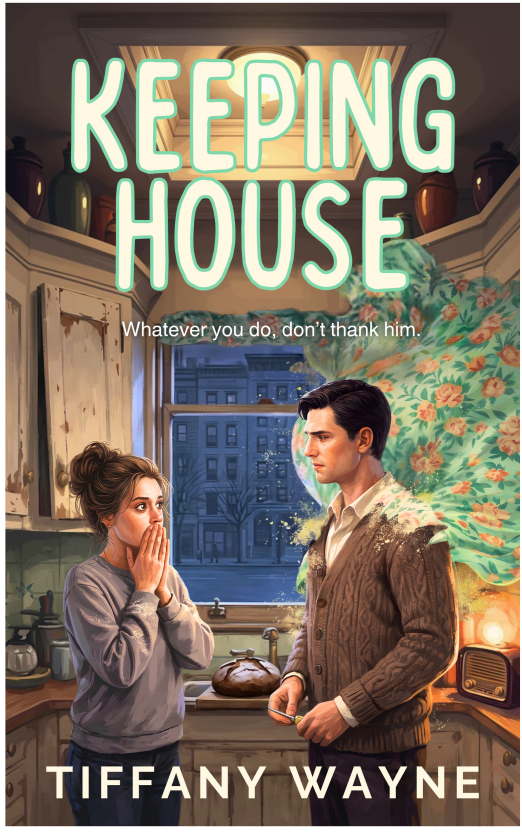
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Keeping House

An exclusive novelette from the After Dark in Chicago series


KEEPING HOUSE
Whatever you do, don't thank him.
TIFFANY WAYNE

Chapter 1 - Claire

Thirty-Seven Violations

I thanked the closing attorney, the loan officer, the woman from the title company, the notary, and the pen.

The pen was an accident. It was a nice pen, heavy, with the title company's name on the side in gold, and I'd signed my name with it forty-one times in an hour and a half, and when I set it down at the end I said, "Thank you," to it, out loud, in a conference room on LaSalle Street, with four professionals watching.

The loan officer looked at the pen. Then at me.

"Habit," I said.

"Congratulations, Ms. Briggs," said the loan officer, who had been very clear with me, twice, about the terms of my rehab loan. "Ninety days."

"Ninety days," I said. "Thank you so much."

Here are the terms, because I've had them memorized since August. I had bought a three-flat. A greystone, built

in 1912, on Francisco Avenue, a block off the boulevard in Logan Square, with a bay window on every floor and a stone lion over the door with a chipped nose. I'd bought it with every dollar I had saved in fourteen years of getting up at nine p.m. to make other people's bread, plus a loan from a bank that had looked at me the way you'd look at a cake that hadn't risen yet. I'd live on the second floor. The first and third floors would be rentals. The rent from them would pay the mortgage. And if those two units weren't registered, inspected and passed by the City of Chicago in ninety days, the loan converted to a rate I had looked up once, on my phone, at a bus stop, and then had to sit down on the bench.

So that was the house.

I'd seen it twice before I bought it. Both times it was empty, with the furniture gone and the radiators cold and a lot of dust in the light from the bay windows, and both times I'd stood in the second-floor kitchen under a grandmother's sort of scrutiny, as if somebody wanted to see if I'd been eating. I don't usually get that in real estate.

The seller was a woman named Ida Fenner, ninety-one, who had lived there for sixty years and had moved into assisted living in the spring. I never met her. Her nephew handled the sale. He told me the house had been "very well kept" and then said, "Very, very well kept," again, in a strange voice, and then he wouldn't say anything else about it.

* * *

The city inspector came at four, an hour after closing, because I'd booked him before I owned the house. I'm not proud of that. I'm a planner.

His name was Dale Sorensen. He was about sixty, with a clipboard, a city windbreaker, a camera on a lanyard, and the face of a man who had seen every way a building can disappoint you and had made his peace with all of them. He walked through both rental units in two hours without saying anything but numbers. He photographed everything. He photographed fixtures I'd have walked straight past. He photographed the stone lion.

"Is the lion a problem?" I said.

"The lion is fine," said Dale. "I photograph the lion for context."

At six, in the front hall, he tore three pages off his clipboard and handed them to me.

"Thirty-seven violations," said Dale.

"Thirty-seven," I said.

"Across units one and three. Unit two is owner-occupied. I don't inspect unit two." He looked at me over the clipboard. "Unit two is your problem."

I read the first page standing in the hall.

Item 4: Kitchen faucet, unit 1. Drips (continuous).

Item 9: Back stair handrail, insufficiently attached to stair.

Item 12: Bedroom window, unit 3. Painted shut. Painted shut twice.

Item 19: Smoke detector, unit 3. Contains bird's nest (vacated).

Item 26: Outlet, unit 1 kitchen. Ungrounded. Also upside down.

And at the bottom of the third page, in the same blocky handwriting, underlined:

Item 37: Boiler. See attached. See me.

"What's attached?" I said.

Dale handed me a fourth page. It was a photograph of the boiler in my basement, printed out on his little machine, black and white. It's a big cast-iron box the size of a car, installed in 1948, according to a brass plate on its side, and in the photograph it looked like a shipwreck a museum had dredged up out of Lake Michigan.

"Rental units in the City of Chicago must have heat," said Dale, "from September fifteenth to June first. It is November. Your boiler is, technically, providing heat. But I wouldn't stand next to it."

"Thank you," I said. "Sorry. Thank you so much. Really."

Dale looked at me for a long moment.

"You're welcome," he said, slowly, like a man trying out a word in a foreign language, and left.

* * *

I unpacked one box. I had twenty-six.

I'd hired movers, two brothers named Pete and Sully who carried my couch up the front stairs like a canoe, and I'd thanked them so many times that Sully finally said, "Ma'am, we got paid," and I'd said, "I know, thank you," and he'd given up. The boxes were in the living room in a wall. The bed frame was in pieces in the bedroom. I'd only put together a bookcase, the kind from the big blue store that comes flat with a picture of a man with no face, and when it was standing upright I'd said, "Thank you, Billy," to it, because that's its name. It's on the box.

Then at nine-thirty I went to work.

I'm the night baker at Garland Bakery on Milwaukee Avenue, up in Avondale, and I have been for fourteen years. I come in at ten. I make the rye and the pumpernickel and the white sandwich loaf and the kaiser rolls and the paczki on Fridays and anything else Ozzie decides the neighborhood needs by six a.m., and then at six the day girls come in, and I take the 56 home.

Ozzie Garland is seventy-four and owns the place. He talks to the dough. Not baby talk. He talks to it the way you'd talk to a relative who has disappointed you before and might again. "The rye is nervous tonight," he'll say, poking it. "The rye heard something." The radio over the proofing cabinet is on WDRY 1490 all night, because it has been since before I worked there. Polka till midnight. Then *Margo After Midnight with Dennis* till sunrise.

"You bought it," said Ozzie, when I came in.

"I bought it."

"You look like you bought it." He looked at me over his glasses, with flour on them. "How many?"

"Thirty-seven."

Ozzie whistled. The rye, I'm told, sank a little.

I worked the whole night with the inspection list in my apron pocket. Every time I had a minute, I took it out and read it again. Faucet. Handrail. Window. Window. Bird's nest. I did the math on plumbers, electricians, painters. I did the math on a boiler man. I did the math, at three in the morning, on whether I could do some of it myself with a book from the library, and how many nights I could go without sleep, and whether the rye would notice.

At 2:14, on the radio over the proofing cabinet, the nightly cremation ad came on, a woman's flat voice over an organ: *Przybylski and Sons Discount Cremation, serving Chicago's Northwest Side since 1952. Dust to dust. We'll take it from here.*

"I'd take it from here," I said to the rye.

"Don't say that to the rye," said Ozzie.

* * *

I got home at 6:40 in the morning. It was still dark. I climbed the front stairs to the second floor, unlocked my door, turned on the kitchen light, and stopped.

The kitchen faucet wasn't dripping.

I hadn't noticed it dripping the night before. I noticed now, because it had stopped, and because there was a small, neat pile on the drain board beside it: one old rubber washer, one small brass screw, and a folded square of paper towel, laid out like surgical instruments.

The cabinet door over the stove, which had hung by one hinge since the first time I saw the house, was hanging by two.

And in the living room, my wall of boxes was gone.

I don't mean stolen. I mean unpacked. My books were on Billy, alphabetized by author, and on a second shelf someone had built out of the leftover boards from the box Billy came in, which I'd put out for recycling, and which was now holding my cookbooks. My dishes were in the cabinets. My towels were folded in hotel thirds in the hall closet. My winter coats were hung by length. And on every box that had been emptied and flattened and stacked by the back door, someone had written what had

been in it, in the most beautiful handwriting I'd ever seen. Copperplate, like on an old wedding invitation, in pencil.

Crockery.

Linens.

Sundries.

I stood in my living room in my coat and my clogs, with flour still on my arms, at a quarter to seven in the morning, and read *Sundries* in pencil for a long time.

Then I checked every lock, every window and every closet in the apartment, holding a rolling pin. I checked under the bed frame, which was now a bed, made, with hospital corners. I checked the pantry, which is a little room off the kitchen with a door that has an old glass knob and a hook-and-eye latch, and which smelled, very faintly, like lemon oil.

There was nobody.

Here's the part that matters. I wasn't scared. I should have been. I was relieved, first, all the way through, like putting down a box I'd been carrying up three flights. And then, right behind the relief, the old, sick feeling I've had my whole life, the one that comes the second anybody does anything for me.

I owed somebody.

I don't like to owe. I keep track. I have an app on my phone called IOU that I downloaded at nineteen and have never deleted, and in it is every favor anybody has done for me since then, and every one I've paid back. Rides. Shifts covered. The time my neighbor in Albany Park lent me a ladder. Everything gets entered, and everything gets settled, and when it's settled I check it off. It's the

most satisfying thing I know, checking it off. It's better than bread coming out right.

There was no line in the app for *Sundries.*

So I did what I could. I took a brown paper grocery bag out from under the sink, which is where someone had folded and put my grocery bags, and I took a marker out of the drawer by the stove, which is where someone had put my markers, and I wrote on the bag in big block capitals:

THANK YOU SO MUCH!!

I thought about it. Then I added, underneath, smaller:

(Whoever you are.)

I propped it against the sugar canister on the counter, where anyone standing at the sink would see it.

Somewhere inside the kitchen wall, behind the old flowered wallpaper over the stove, something sighed.

It was a small sound. Like a draft. Like the house settling. I decided it was the house settling.

Then I went to bed in my made bed with the hospital corners, and slept until three.

* * *

Nothing else was fixed when I woke up.

I'd half expected the handrail, or the outlet. I'd hoped. I'd lain in bed with my eyes closed in the afternoon light planning the next repairs for my invisible contractor, as if I were scheduling a bake. But when I walked through the kitchen at a quarter past three in my robe, everything was where it had been at a quarter to seven. The cabinet door was still hung. The faucet was still quiet. The boxes were

still flat. My grocery bag was still propped against the sugar canister, saying *THANK YOU SO MUCH!!* to nobody.

I showered. It was November, so by the time I came out, at ten to five, the light was already gone from the windows, and the streetlights on Francisco were on.

My grocery bag had a reply on it.

It was written under mine. In pencil. In that handwriting.

Please don't.

—H.

I stood there with my coffee.

"Please don't what?" I said, out loud, to my empty kitchen.

The kitchen didn't answer. The radiator under the window knocked once, the way a person clears their throat when they've decided not to get involved.

* * *

That night at work I thanked the dough.

I didn't notice I was doing it. I was shaping kaisers, and every time I finished one I said "thank you" to it under my breath, the way you'd tap a table. Ozzie came over around three and stood next to me with his arms folded until I looked up.

"You're thanking the rolls," said Ozzie.

"I'm not."

"You thanked the oven twice. You thanked the mixer. You said 'thank you, sorry' to the walk-in when you shut the door on it." He took the dough scraper out of my hand. "Whatever it is, go home and look at it. The rye can't take this."

"Ozzie, I can't—"

"Claire." He doesn't call me Claire. He calls me *kid,* and has since I was twenty-one. "Fourteen years. You've covered for me eleven times. You came in the night my Vera had the surgery. You came in during the blizzard. I've got it written down."

"You don't have it written down."

"I've got it written down in here," said Ozzie, poking his own chest with a floury finger. "Go home. Don't thank me. Go."

I went. I didn't thank him. It was very hard. I said "okay" four times on the way to the door and once to the bus.

* * *

I got home at 4:30 in the morning, two hours early, and climbed the stairs in my socks with my clogs in my hand.

I don't know why I took them off. I came up very quietly, past the third stair from the top, which creaks, and which I stepped over, and I let myself in so slowly that the latch didn't click.

The kitchen light was on.

There was a man in my kitchen.

He was standing at the cabinet over the refrigerator, the one that has never closed all the way, with the door off its hinges and resting against his hip, holding a tiny screwdriver in his teeth. He was tall, as tall as the doorway behind him, almost exactly, like he'd been measured for it. He was maybe forty. He had dark hair going gray at the sides, cut very short, and he was wearing a collarless white shirt with the sleeves held up by elastic bands above his elbows, and gray wool trousers, and over it all a

cardigan. A heavy brown cardigan, with leather buttons. The kind of cardigan you see in old photographs of men standing in front of new automobiles.

He smelled like lemon oil and sawdust and, very faintly, coal smoke, though nobody's burned coal on Francisco Avenue since before I was born.

He didn't move. That's what I noticed first. His shoulders had gone rigid; he'd heard me. And he didn't turn around, and he didn't keep working. He just stopped, all of him, with the door against his hip and the screwdriver in his teeth, the way a deer stops in a yard.

Very slowly, he took the screwdriver out of his mouth.

"Good morning, Miss Briggs," he said.

His voice was low and careful and very polite, with an old-fashioned finish on it, like furniture. And underneath that, very strangely, there was a sound I recognized. A late-night flatness. A radio voice. The kind of voice you'd hear at three in the morning over a proofing cabinet.

"Hi," I said.

"I can't finish this while you're watching," he said. He still hadn't turned around. "I'm terribly sorry. It's a rule. I'll have to leave the door off until you're asleep."

"That's okay."

"It isn't, but thank you for saying so." A pause. "Please don't say it back."

"Say what?"

He turned around then.

He had a long, serious face, the kind of face you'd trust to hold your coat, and very dark eyes, and he looked at me the way the house had looked at me the first time I

walked into it. Like he'd been waiting to see if I'd been eating.

"Anything," he said, "along the lines of what you wrote on the grocery bag."

I looked at the cabinet door against his hip. I looked at the living room through the doorway, at Billy and the cookbook shelf built out of the box Billy came in. I thought about *Sundries.* I thought about the hospital corners. The thanks came up in me, enormous and automatic, like putting your hand out to catch a ball, and I couldn't stop it. I've never once in my life been able to stop it.

"I'm sorry," I said. "I have to. Thank you so m—"

He was gone.

He was standing in my kitchen in his cardigan with my cabinet door against his hip, and then he wasn't, and the cabinet door fell over, slowly, and landed flat on the linoleum with a bang that echoed down the back stairs.

And in the wall over the stove, behind the flowered wallpaper, something sighed.

It was a long sigh. A tired one. A sigh like a man sitting down on the edge of a bed at the end of a very long day. Plaster dust sifted down out of the crack along the ceiling and settled on the stove, very fine, like flour.

I stood in the kitchen with my clogs in my hand.

"Sorry," I said to the wall.

Somewhere behind the wallpaper, faint and muffled and polite, a man's voice said, "That one's fine."

Chapter 2 – Hayes

Wages

The inside of a wall is not as bad as people think. People don't think about it at all, which is my point.

The walls of this house are lath and horsehair plaster, three-quarters of an inch thick, laid by a crew of four Germans and a boy in the spring of 1912. Between the lath and the brick there are three inches of dark. In that dark there are the old gas pipes from before the house was electrified, capped since 1927; a great deal of dust; the *Chicago Daily Tribune* for April 9th, 1912, which the plasterers stuffed into the gaps for insulation, and which I have read so many times I can recite the box scores; and a mouse, with whom I have an understanding.

That's where I go when I'm thanked. I don't decide to. It just happens, the way your knee jumps when the doctor taps it. Someone in the household says it, or writes it, and means it about my work, and I am in the wall, and I stay in the wall until the next nightfall. I can hear everything.

I can't do anything. It's like being a radio that's been switched off but is still listening.

I heard her stand in the kitchen for a long time after she said it, with her shoes in her hand.

Then she picked up the cabinet door off the floor, carefully, and leaned it against the refrigerator, and said, "Sorry," to it. Then I heard her go to bed.

The mouse looked at me.

"I know," I said.

* * *

I should introduce myself. Nobody else is going to.

I'm the brownie of this house. I don't care for the word. It makes people picture something small and brown with pointed ears, in a children's book, sitting in a teacup. I'm the height of the doorframes in this house, six feet and two inches exactly, because I grew to fit them. I'm brown only in the cardigan. And I have never sat in a teacup, though in 1931 the youngest Pike boy put me in a story for school in which I did, and it got an A, and I have never forgiven him.

A brownie comes with the house itself, the minute somebody lights the first fire in it. The land and the family have no say in it. The first fire in this house was lit on the evening of November 3rd, 1912, in the kitchen stove on the second floor, by a woman named Mrs. Harold Pike, who was crying because she had burned the potatoes. I was standing in the pantry. I don't know where I was before that. I don't think I was.

There are rules. I didn't make them. I've never met anyone who did.

I belong to the house and its lot. I can go anywhere from the basement to the attic, out the back door to the yard, and down the yard to the coach house where the Pikes kept a horse until 1924. I can't go past the front gate. I've tried. It's not a wall. It's more like reaching the end of a sentence.

I work when nobody in the household is watching. If one of them watches me, the work won't take. A nail won't go in. A screw won't turn. I can stand there with the screwdriver in my hand, and that's all I can do, stand there.

I'm paid in food. Something left out at night. That's wages, and I'm obliged to take it.

I can't touch cold iron.

And I am never, ever to be thanked.

* * *

The Pikes had a daughter named Agnes, and in the spring of 1913, when she was six, she saw me.

Children see me more than adults do. Adults look straight through a man in a cardigan in their own kitchen at four in the morning, because they know he can't be there. Children don't know anything yet. Agnes Pike walked into the coach house one morning to see the horse and found me mending the bridle, and she looked at me for a long time, and then she said, "You live in the hay."

I didn't. I lived in the house. But I'd been sitting in the hay.

"You're Hay," said Agnes, with the certainty of a six-year-old who has just named something.

She told her mother at breakfast that a man called Hay lived in the coach house and fixed things. Mrs. Pike, who was a sensible woman from Ohio and had already noticed that her potatoes no longer burned, put down her coffee and said, "Hayes, dear. If he's going to have a name, it ought to sound respectable."

So I'm Hayes. I have been for a hundred and thirteen years. It's the only thing anybody in this house ever gave me that I've been allowed to keep.

* * *

The Pikes thanked me in 1914.

Mr. Pike did. He came down to the basement one night in his nightshirt to see who'd been fixing the furnace grate, and he saw me, and he was a decent man, a street-car conductor, and he said, "Well, thank you kindly, sir," and held out his hand.

I was in the walls before he could shake it.

That's the part nobody understands. The ones who thank me are the kind ones. Every family that's lived here has been kind, in its way, and sooner or later, every one of them looked at what I'd done and wanted to say so. The Pikes. The Novotnys, after the Pikes moved to Oak Park. The Healys. A Mr. and Mrs. Gutterman, who were only here four years but thanked me so often I hardly ever got out of the plaster.

Then, in 1965, the Fenners. Ida Fenner was thirty-one. Her mother had grown up in a house with a brownie in it, on Throop Street, and her mother had told her the rules, and Ida followed them.

For sixty years, every single night, Ida Fenner put a saucer of milk and two saltines on the pantry shelf. Every night, she shut the pantry door and latched it with the little hook-and-eye, so she wouldn't see me. And every night, for sixty years, she sat on a kitchen chair on the other side of that door and talked to me through it.

She told me about her day. She told me about Ray, her husband, who sold insurance, and their son, who moved to Arizona. She told me about the Cubs. She told me when Ray passed, in 1994, through the door, in a very steady voice, and then she didn't say anything for an hour, and neither did I, and we sat there on either side of the pantry door in the dark.

After that first week, she never thanked me again. Not in sixty years. I don't know how she did it. I've watched people try for a week.

She never once saw my face, either. That was the other half of it. She said it was easier not to look.

Ida Fenner was the best employer I've ever had. And I sat on the other side of a door from her for sixty years and she never once looked at me, and I've thought about that every day since April, when her nephew came and helped her down the front steps to a car, and the house went quiet.

Seven months of quiet. I swept a lot.

Then a woman came up the stairs with flour in her hair and thanked a bookcase.

* * *

At nightfall, I came out of the wall.

It's like stepping out of cold water. The house comes back to you all at once: every board, every pipe, every window sash, where the draft gets in on the third floor, which radiator is about to knock. And every person in it. I know where everyone in the house is the way you know where your own hands are. I don't have to look.

She was in the kitchen. Sitting at the table. Awake.

I stood in the hall outside the kitchen door for a minute. I could feel her in there, sitting very straight, her heels hooked on the rung of the chair, and a small, round weight on the table in front of her. She'd been sitting there long enough for the waiting to reach me in the hall.

I knocked on the doorframe.

"Come in," she said. "Sorry. It's— Can you come in? Is that allowed?"

"It's my kitchen, Miss Briggs," I said, and came in. "It's also yours. It's complicated."

She was in a gray sweatshirt with GARLAND BAKERY on it, and her hair was up, and there was a burn scar on her right forearm, an old one, shiny, the shape of an oven rack. She looked at me straight on, as if I were exactly as real as the table. Nobody in this house has looked at me like that since Agnes Pike. I'd forgotten how that felt. I'd like to say it felt good. Mostly it felt like standing too close to a stove.

On the table in front of her was a loaf of bread.

"I'm not going to say it," she said. "I've been practicing. I'm not going to say it. I just want to understand what happened."

So I sat down across from her, and I told her.

The house. The fire. The hay. The rules, in order. I told her about Mr. Pike and his hand. I told her about the walls, and the *Daily Tribune* for April 9th, 1912, and the mouse.

She listened like a person taking an order. When I got to the part about the thanks, she put both hands flat on the table.

"Any words?" she said.

"Any words that mean it. About my work."

"Written?"

"Written counts. You found that out."

"What if I'm not *saying* it? What if I'm— I'm grateful. Is *grateful* okay? I'm just stating a fact. I'm grateful about the faucet."

The kitchen got very quiet. I sat there, at the table, waiting for the plaster. Nothing happened.

"That's a fact about you," I said slowly. "Not to me."

"Okay. Okay." She kept both hands flat on the table. "So I can say I appreciate— no. I can say *I'm aware.* I'm aware of the faucet. I'm aware of the bookcase you built out of the box the bookcase came in."

"That bookcase," I said, before I could help it, "came with instructions, Miss Briggs. They were pictures. Of a man with no face."

"I know."

"He was holding the wrong end of a screwdriver in four of them."

"I know." She almost smiled. "I'm aware of the cookbook shelf. I'm aware of *Sundries.*"

"The word was the best I could do," I said. "Some of those boxes were very mixed."

She laughed. It was short and surprised and it went straight into the floorboards and down through the house and I felt it in the basement, which has never happened, and I'm not going to explain that. I can't.

Then she looked down at the loaf.

* * *

"Mrs. Fenner's nephew said you got milk," she said. "When I asked about the house. He said his aunt left milk out every night for sixty years and he never knew why, and he thought maybe she had a cat, except she didn't have a cat."

"Milk," I said. "And two saltines."

"Every night."

"Every night since 1965."

"Saltines," said Claire Briggs, in the voice of a woman who has spent fourteen years making bread and has heard something truly terrible.

She pushed the loaf across the table to me.

"It's rye," she said. "I made it this morning. Last night. At work. It's from the second bake, so it's the good one. Ozzie says the first bake is for the customers and the second bake is for the people who know." She pulled her hands back into her lap, like she was trying to keep them from doing anything else. "It's not thanks. I need you to know that. It's not thanks. It's— If you're doing the work, you get paid. It's wages. I looked it up."

"You looked it up."

"There's a lot of folklore on the internet. Most of it's wrong. But they all say wages."

I looked at the loaf.

It was dark and round, with a crust like a polished shoe and a little split along the top where it had opened up in the oven, and it was still, very faintly, warm, as if she'd held it in her coat on the bus. The smell reached across the table: caraway and sour, and under that the smell of the yard after rain.

I had never eaten fresh bread. Not once. Mrs. Pike burned the potatoes that first night, and the bread too, and after that she bought it from the baker on Armitage, and after that everyone bought it in a wrapper. For sixty years I had milk and saltines. Before that, the Healys gave me the crusts. The Guttermans gave me Jell-O.

I tore off the heel.

I'm not going to describe it. A hundred and thirteen years is a long time to wait for anything, and I'd rather keep it. I'll only say that it was warm, and that she watched me eat it, and that I didn't go into the walls, because somebody was paying what they owed, in full, to the last crumb, and looking at me while they did it.

When I looked up, she had both hands pressed over her mouth. Her eyes were very bright.

"Don't," I said.

She nodded behind her hands.

"Miss Briggs."

"I'm not," she said through her fingers. "I'm not saying anything. I'm aware. I'm just extremely aware."

* * *

She left for work at nine-thirty. At nine-thirty-one I put the cabinet door back on.

I had about sixteen hours before Dale Sorensen came back. She'd told me. Thursday at two, the second inspection, and the bank wanted the inspection report by Monday. She told me in the doorway in her coat, with her bag over her shoulder, reading the list off the three sheets of paper, item by item, as if she were giving me directions to somewhere, and every time she got to the end of an item she opened her mouth, and closed it, and said, "Okay," instead.

I did the faucet in unit one that night. Washer, seat, packing nut. I did the outlet, which some genius had installed upside down in 1971. I did the back handrail and the smoke detector, and returned the nest to the gutter, where it's been looked after. I did the windows on the third floor, both coats of paint, and the closet door, and the bathroom tile, and the sash cords, and eleven more, and the house hummed around me the way it hasn't since April, every room with somebody's work going on in it.

By ten to four on Thursday morning I'd done thirty-six.

Then, with her still away at the bakery, I went down to the basement and stood in front of the thirty-seventh.

It's a 1948 cast-iron boiler the size of a Buick. I've hated it since 1948. It's the only thing in this house I've never been able to touch, and it knows it. It sits there in the dark in the corner where the coal bin used to be, ticking and muttering and leaking a little from a fitting at the bottom,

with its pilot light going small and blue and uncertain, like a man trying to remember a phone number.

I put my hand out. I stopped an inch from the iron. The iron's cold reached my hand, a cold my kind knows, like a word nobody wants to hear.

Upstairs, on the kitchen table, I left her a note on the back of Dale's list. I took care with the handwriting. It's the only thing I've got that's mine.

Thirty-six of thirty-seven, Miss Briggs.

I can't do the boiler. I can't touch it. I never have.

And under that, because I knew what she'd ask, and I knew who'd know the answer:

Mrs. Fenner had someone for it. Ask her.

Chapter 3 – Claire

Not So Much as a Sock

Kedzie Gardens is a six-story brick building on Kedzie Avenue with a fountain out front that has been turned off for the winter and a lobby that smells like coffee cake and Pine-Sol. I brought a coffee cake. I didn't know what else to bring a ninety-one-year-old woman whose house I'd bought, and whose brownie I'd thanked into a wall.

Ida Fenner was in the sunroom on the third floor, in a wheelchair by the window, doing a crossword in pen. She was very small and very straight, with white hair set in waves and a cardigan buttoned to the throat, and she looked at me over her glasses when the aide brought me in the way you'd look at a delivery you hadn't ordered.

"You're the girl who bought my house," she said.

"Yes, ma'am. Claire Briggs. I brought a coffee cake."

"From where?"

"From me. I'm a baker. Garland's, on Milwaukee."

Ida Fenner took the foil off the coffee cake and looked at it for a long time. Then she broke off a corner, ate it, and chewed, with her eyes closed, while I stood there holding my coat.

"Sit," she said. "That's a real coffee cake. Here they give you a coffee cake that's been in a meeting."

I sat. She folded the crossword in half.

"So," said Ida. "You said it."

"I said it."

"How many times?"

"Twice," I said. "Once on a grocery bag."

"Well, that's all right," said Ida. "I said it once myself. The first week. I was thirty-one and nobody had ever fixed my sink without being asked, and it just came out of me, and I heard him go into the wall over the stove, and I sat down on the kitchen floor and cried." She folded her hands on top of the crossword. "Then I never said it again. Sixty years."

"How?"

Ida stuck out her tongue.

I didn't understand at first. Then I leaned closer. On the left side, near the tip, was a small, hard, pale spot, like a callus on a finger.

"Sixty years of biting it," said Ida Fenner, and put her tongue away.

* * *

She told me everything. She told it to me like a recipe, with exact amounts.

"One saucer of milk, whole, not skim, he doesn't like skim. Two saltines. On the pantry shelf, second from the

top, every night, ten o'clock. Shut the pantry door and latch it." She held up one bony finger. "You don't watch him. You don't go looking for him. He does the work when you're asleep. You don't say anything about the work. You don't write anything about the work. If something's fixed in the morning, you walk right past it like it was always that way." She paused. "That's the hardest part. Walking past it."

"He said you talked to him."

Ida's hands went still on the folded crossword.

"Every night," she said. "Through the pantry door. I'd pull a chair up to it. I told him everything. My whole life." She looked out the window at the turned-off fountain. "He's a good listener. Ray was a good man, God rest him, but he was not a listener. Hayes listens like you're the radio."

"Who did the boiler?" I said.

"Ray. Until 1994. Then me." She sniffed. "There's a manual in a coffee can on the shelf over the workbench. Chock Full o'Nuts. You'll want the pliers with the blue handles and a great deal of patience. That boiler is a son of a gun."

"He said he can't touch it."

"He can't touch iron. It's in all the stories. My mother's brownie on Throop Street couldn't either. They had a cast-iron skillet she had to keep wrapped in a dish towel." Ida looked at me. "He'll stand there and tell you what to do. He'll know every bolt. But you'll have to do it with your own two hands, honey, and you'll be watching him, so he can't help." She smiled, a little, for the first time. "Ray

never knew who was telling him. He thought he just had a good instinct for boilers."

* * *

I should have gone then. I had to be home by two for Dale, and I hadn't slept, and I could feel the day sitting on the backs of my eyes like a hand.

But Ida Fenner put down her pen and leaned forward in her wheelchair, and said, in a voice that didn't sound like a recipe at all:

"What does he look like?"

I stared at her.

"Sixty years," said Ida, "and I never looked. Mother said it was easier. She said if you look at them, you start to want to say it, and then you'll say it, and then you'll spend your life saying it, and he'll spend his in the walls." She looked down at her hands. "So I kept the door shut. And I told him every single thing about me for sixty years, and I don't know if he's got a beard."

"He doesn't have a beard," I said.

Ida held up her hand, fast.

"Don't," she said. "Don't tell me. I changed my mind. If you tell me, I'll want to see. And I'm not going back there, and I'm ninety-one, and I've got a callus on my tongue the size of a lentil." She took a breath. "Just tell me he's all right."

"He's all right."

"Does he still do the third stair? The one from the top? It creaks. I always asked him to leave it. So I'd know when Ray came up."

"It still creaks."

"Good," said Ida Fenner, and looked out the window for a while.

* * *

When the aide came back to say my time was up, Ida grabbed my wrist.

She had a grip like a hinge. Every bone in her hand pressed against my wrist.

"One more thing," she said. "The most important thing. More important than the milk."

"Okay."

"Don't you ever give him clothes."

I waited.

"Not a coat. Not a hat. Not so much as a sock," said Ida. "You give a brownie clothes, the house lets go of him. He's free. He can walk right out the front gate." Her hand tightened. "And they go, honey. That's what my mother said, and her mother. Every one of them that's ever been freed. A house that gives you clothes is a house that's done with you. They take the coat and walk out the gate and never come back. Never once." She let go of my wrist. "So you leave the milk, and you bite your tongue, and you keep him. That's the only way there is."

I stood up. I put on my coat. I didn't say thank you to Ida Fenner. I want to be honest: it nearly killed me. I said, "I'll come back," instead.

"Bring the coffee cake," said Ida, and picked up her pen.

* * *

Dale Sorensen arrived at 1:58 p.m. with his clipboard, his windbreaker and his camera on its lanyard, and stood

on my front walk looking up at the stone lion over the door for a long time.

"Somebody fixed the lion," he said.

I looked up. The lion's nose, which had been chipped off since before I'd ever seen the house, was a nose again. A good one. You couldn't see the seam.

"It wasn't on the list," said Dale.

"No," I said.

He photographed it. For context.

Then he went through units one and three with his clipboard, item by item, all thirty-seven, and I followed him, and I watched a man who has seen every way a building can disappoint you be disappointed by nothing at all.

The faucet: tight. The outlet: right side up, grounded, with a new cover plate that was the same impossible 1912 brass as all the others in the house. The windows on the third floor went up and down on their sash cords as smooth as a theater curtain. When Dale put his weight on the back handrail, it held as if it had been part of the stair since before the stair.

Dale stood in the unit-three bathroom for a long time looking at the tile.

"This is original," he said.

"Yes."

"This was cracked on Monday. Six tiles. I have photographs." He held up the camera like evidence. "These are original. 1912. They don't make this tile. Where did your contractor get original tile?"

I opened my mouth. I had nothing in it.

"The coach house," said a voice from the hallway. "There were two boxes left over in the coach house. Mr. Pike ordered extra."

Hayes was standing in the bathroom door.

I hadn't heard him come up. I hadn't known he would. He was in his cardigan, with his sleeve garters on and his hands folded in front of him, very polite, very still, and in the bright two o'clock light through the bathroom window he looked about as solid and ordinary as a man can look, which was, it turns out, very.

He wasn't working. He couldn't, with me watching him. He was just standing there.

Dale looked at him for a while.

"You're the contractor," said Dale.

"I'm with the house," said Hayes.

"Name?"

"Hayes."

"License number?"

Hayes thought about this. "I don't have a number," he said. "I've been at this address since 1912."

There was a long pause. Dale Sorensen looked at the cardigan. He looked at the sleeve garters. He looked at the tile that you can't get anymore, and the lion that was a lion again, and the outlet that had been upside down since 1971 and wasn't. He had the expression of a man adding up a column of figures and getting a number he didn't care for, and deciding, for reasons of his own, to keep it.

Then he made an entry on his clipboard. I read it upside down.

Work performed by: Hayes (affiliated w/ house).

"Thirty-six," said Dale, and turned the page.

* * *

The boiler took him forty minutes.

He stood in front of it in the basement with a flashlight, under the one bare bulb, and photographed it from every side, and opened its little iron doors and looked inside and closed them, and made a sound in his throat like a doctor reading an X-ray he'd hoped not to see. Hayes stood at the bottom of the basement stairs, as far from it as the basement allowed, and didn't say anything at all.

"Thermocouple's going," said Dale. "Burner's dirty. Sediment in the bottom. Relief valve's weeping. Pressure gauge reads what it wants." He tore off a page. "Fail."

"Okay."

"Rental units must have heat. You have fourteen days to fix it or replace it. On day fifteen I write the citation and a copy goes to your lender." He looked at me over the clipboard. "Replacement on a unit this size, you're looking at twelve, fourteen thousand."

I had four hundred and eleven dollars in checking. I had it memorized.

"I'll fix it," I said.

"You will," said Dale. He said it as if he'd be back to check. He looked over at Hayes, at the bottom of the stairs, at the cardigan and the folded hands. "And your affiliated party?"

"He can't touch it," I said. "He's— It's a thing with iron."

"Allergy," said Hayes.

Dale looked at him for one more long, flat moment. Then he wrote *allergy* on the clipboard, under *affiliated w/ house,* and underlined it, and went up the stairs.

At the front door he stopped, and turned around, and looked up at the lion one more time.

"You're welcome," he said to me, out of nowhere, as if answering something I'd said on Monday, and left.

* * *

When the door closed, the house was very quiet.

I went back down to the basement. Hayes was still at the bottom of the stairs, looking at the boiler from across the room the way you'd look at a dog that had bitten you once.

"I went to see Mrs. Fenner," I said.

He went very still.

"She's all right," I said. "She's doing the crossword in pen. She says skim milk is an insult. She wanted to know if you have a beard, and then she didn't want to know." I stopped. "She asked about the third stair."

Hayes didn't say anything for a while. He looked at the floor.

"The third stair," he said finally, "is staying."

"I know."

"She'd like that," he said, very quietly, to the floor.

I looked at the boiler. It ticked at me. Its small blue pilot light wavered, like a candle in a window at the end of a long road. Fourteen days. Four hundred and eleven dollars. A coffee can on a shelf with a manual in it, and a pair of pliers with blue handles, and a man standing as far away from me as the basement allowed, who knew

every bolt in it and couldn't put his hand on a single one of them.

"Mrs. Fenner said you'd tell me what to do," I said. "She said you'd stand there and know every bolt, and I'd have to do it myself, with my own two hands, while I'm watching."

Hayes looked up.

"Sunday's my night off," I said. "Teach me."

Chapter 4 – Hayes

Cold Iron

She came down to the basement on Sunday night at nine o'clock in overalls, with her hair tied up in a bandanna, carrying the Chock Full o'Nuts can, a bucket, a flashlight, a thermocouple from the hardware store on Milwaukee Avenue in a plastic clamshell, and a plate with a slice of rye on it, buttered, which she set down on the workbench beside me.

"Wages," she said. "In advance."

"You're not supposed to pay in advance."

"I looked it up. Nobody says you can't." She put the coffee can on the floor in front of the boiler and knelt beside it like a woman about to defuse a bomb. "Okay. Where do I start?"

I stood by the workbench, eight feet from the iron, which is as close as I can comfortably get. I've stood there a great many times. I stood there in 1948 when two men named Walsh brought it down the coal chute in

pieces and assembled it, swearing, over two days. I stood there for every winter Ray Fenner lived here, giving him instructions he thought were instinct. I stood there for thirty-one winters after that while Ida did it herself, in a housecoat, with the manual open on the floor, listening when I said *the left valve first, Ida*.

I had never once stood there and been seen.

"Start with the drain," I said. "Bottom left. The brass spigot. Put the bucket under it first."

* * *

She put the bucket under it second.

I want to be fair to her. She has burn scars up her forearms from fourteen years of pulling racks out of ovens, and she can tell you the temperature of a room by how fast a loaf rises in it, and she lifted the boiler's front panel off by herself, which Ray Fenner never once managed without saying a word the Pikes wouldn't have had in the house. But a 1948 boiler drain doesn't open slowly. It opens the way a dam opens.

Seventy-seven years of sediment came out of it in a single brown roar and hit her square in the clogs.

"Oh," said Claire Briggs. "Oh, no. Oh, that's— Okay. Okay." She got the bucket under it. She stood there in a puddle of what looked like coffee grounds and smelled like a drowned penny, watching it fill. "Thank you," she said, to the bucket.

I waited for the plaster. Nothing happened. Buckets don't count.

"That was the hard part," I said.

"Was it?"

"No," I said. "I wanted to be encouraging."

She laughed, kneeling in the sludge. It ran up the basement stairs and into the kitchen and along the second-floor hall, finding every pipe. I felt it in the third stair. I don't know how to explain to someone who isn't a house what it's like to have a laugh go through you like that. The closest I can come is: imagine somebody turned on every light in a building you've lived in alone for seven months, all at once, without asking.

* * *

The thermocouple was next.

It's a copper tube that runs from the gas valve to the pilot light, and it tells the boiler whether the flame is lit, and this one had been lying to it since about 1990. It's held on at both ends by fittings, and the fittings are on iron, and she had to lie on her back on the basement floor with her head inside the burner compartment and a flashlight in her teeth while I told her which way to turn the fittings.

"Lefty-loosey," I said.

"I *know* lefty-loosey."

"The Walsh brothers didn't. That one's reverse-threaded."

There was a pause inside the boiler. Then: "Why would anyone reverse-thread a—"

"I've been asking that since 1948."

She got it out. She held it up in the light, the old thermocouple, black with soot and bent like a question mark, and gave it the same approving look she'd given the loaf

when she handed it to me, as if it had done something brave.

"Thank y—" she said to me, and stopped so hard I heard her teeth click.

The house held still. I held still. Somewhere in the walls, the mouse held still.

"—to the thermocouple," said Claire, carefully, looking at the thermocouple. "For its service."

I took my hands off the workbench. "That's allowed."

"I know it's allowed. I was *saying* it to the *thermocouple.*"

"You looked at me first."

"I looked at you *and then* the thermocouple. It's the destination that counts." She pointed the old part at me like a baton. "I'm aware of you. I'm extremely aware of you. Hand me the new one, please."

"I can't," I said. "It's going on iron."

"It's in a plastic clamshell."

"It's going on iron, Miss Briggs, and you're watching me work, and it won't take." I folded my hands. "I'm afraid this is a one-woman show."

"Fine," she said, and lay back down on the floor and went in after it, and from inside the boiler I heard her say, very quietly, to the boiler, "Thank you for your patience."

* * *

The pilot wouldn't light.

That's the third part, and it's the part every boiler saves for last. You hold the gas knob down, and you hold the long match to the little nozzle, and the gas comes, and the flame catches, blue and small, and you hold it there

for one full minute so the new thermocouple can warm up and believe in it, and then you let go of the knob.

She held it for a minute. She let go. The flame went out.

"No," she said.

She did it again. She held it for two minutes this time, kneeling in her wet overalls on the basement floor, her face lit blue from underneath, counting out loud under her breath, *fifty-eight, fifty-nine.* She let go. The flame went out.

"No," she said again, to the boiler, very reasonably, the way you'd say it to a dog on a couch. "No, sir."

"It isn't you," I said.

"It feels like me."

"It's the valve. It's a 1948 valve. It sticks." I came a step closer. It was as close as I'd ever been to that boiler on purpose. Seven feet. I could feel the iron from there, cold as the inside of a word. "Mrs. Fenner never knew this. Ray never knew it. Before you let go, tap the knob twice. Lightly. With one finger."

"Tap it."

"Twice. It's old. It likes to be asked."

She looked at me for a long moment over her shoulder, with the long match burning down in her fingers. Then she turned back to the boiler, and held the knob, and held the flame, and counted to sixty, and tapped the gas knob twice, lightly, with one finger, like knocking on the door of somebody you know is asleep.

She let go.

The pilot stayed lit.

And then the burner caught.

It caught with a sound like a man clearing his throat in a cathedral, an enormous *whump* that went right through the floor, and the whole burner lit at once, a long row of blue flames under the iron, and the boiler shuddered, and creaked, and ticked, and began, after seventy-seven years and a great deal of sediment, to work.

I felt the heat go up through the house.

I don't know how else to put it. It went up the way news goes through a family. The pipes in the basement first, ticking as they warmed. Then the risers in the walls. Then the radiators on the first floor, one by one, *clank, clank, clank,* knocking as the steam reached them, front room, bedroom, kitchen, and then the second floor, and then the third, every radiator in the house waking up and knocking in turn, rising floor by floor toward the roof, like a building full of people standing up to applaud.

Claire sat back on her heels in the sludge and listened to it.

"Is that it?" she said. "Is that the house?"

"That's the house."

She turned around and looked at me. Her face was streaked with soot. There was sediment in her bandanna. She had never looked less like the kind of person anyone would paint, and I've lived with three oil portraits in this house, and I'd have taken her over every one of them.

Then the burner flared.

It does that. It's old. When it first catches, it takes a breath, and sometimes the breath comes out of the front, a long yellow tongue of flame out of the little win-

dow in the burner door. She was kneeling right in front of it. She was looking at me.

"Claire—" I said.

I'd never said her name. I said it on my way across the basement. I don't remember deciding to cross it. I had her by the shoulders and was pulling her back out of the way, and my left arm went past the burner door, and my wrist touched the iron.

The iron makes you feel forgotten. For one second the whole house went out of me: every board and pipe and window sash and every person, gone, like a hand had been taken off my shoulder. Then I was back on the basement floor, sitting down hard, holding my wrist, and the house came back all at once with a roar, and she was kneeling in front of me with both hands around my arm.

She took one hand off my arm and shut the boiler down. The burner went dark.

"Let me see," she said.

There was a mark across the inside of my wrist. White, not red. As if the skin had briefly stopped believing in itself.

"It's nothing," I said. "It goes away."

"Let me see."

She held my wrist in both hands and looked at it under the bare bulb, with the same care she'd given Dale's list. Her hands were warm. They smelled like caraway and sediment and gas. She turned my wrist over, and back, and ran her thumb once, very lightly, along the white mark, and for a hundred and thirteen years I had fixed

every broken thing in this house and nobody had ever once looked to see if I was broken.

"Who's going to fix you?" she said.

I didn't have an answer. I'd never needed one.

She was very close. Her hands were around my wrist, and the radiators were still knocking upstairs, more faintly now, the house settling into its warmth like an old dog onto a rug. I could feel exactly where she was, the way I always can. I didn't need to. I was looking at her anyway.

"May I?" I said.

She knew what I meant. I could feel her know it. Her hands didn't move from my wrist.

"Yes," said Claire.

I kissed her, on the floor of the basement, next to the boiler, in the light of the pilot. I'll keep the rest of it. I'll say only that she tasted like caraway, and that she put one soot-black hand on the side of my face, and that I didn't have to know where she was in the house, because I knew exactly where she was.

When we stopped she looked at me, and she was a little out of breath, and she was still holding my wrist.

"Thank you," she said.

Then she clapped both hands over her mouth.

We both sat there on the basement floor and waited.

Nothing happened. We were still in the basement. I was sitting on the floor of my own basement with soot on my face and a white mark on my wrist and a woman in overalls with her hands over her mouth, and I was absolutely, completely, still there.

"It wasn't work," I said slowly.

She took her hands down. "It wasn't?"

"No," I said. "No, I don't believe it was."

She started to laugh. I did, too. I hadn't laughed out loud since the Truman administration. We sat on the basement floor and laughed until the boiler ticked at us, disapprovingly, and the radiators upstairs knocked twice, like the neighbors.

* * *

Afterward we sat on the bottom basement step, side by side, in the warm, and she ate half the rye, and I ate the other half, and she asked me questions.

She asked what I'd do if I could leave.

I'd never been asked. I thought about it for a long time.

"The lake," I said. "The Pikes went every Sunday in the summer of 1913. The whole family, on the streetcar, to Lincoln Park. They'd come home at night with sand in their shoes and their hems and the cuffs of Mr. Pike's trousers, and the next morning there'd be sand all through the house. In the rugs. In the bathtub. In the beds." I turned the crust over in my hands. "I swept it up every Monday for six summers. I'd hold it in my hand, sometimes, before I put it in the bin. I always wondered where it came from. What it looked like, all together."

She didn't say anything.

"That's all," I said. "Just to see where the sand comes from."

She was quiet for a while. Then she said, very carefully, in a voice I didn't recognize, the voice of a woman reading figures off a bill:

"Hayes. What do you get paid?"

"Bread," I said. "Now."

"Before me."

"Milk. Two saltines."

"And before that?"

"Crusts. Jell-O. Whatever they left."

"For a hundred and thirteen years," said Claire.

"For a hundred and thirteen years," I said. "It's wages. It's all right. It's the rule."

She looked at the boiler for a long time, dark in the corner, waiting. Then she stood up, and brushed off her overalls, and picked up her bucket and her coffee can, and went up the basement stairs without a word.

She didn't say good night. She didn't say thank you to the bucket, or the stairs, or the light switch at the top, which she has thanked every time she's touched it since she moved in.

I stood at the bottom of the stairs and felt her go up through the house. Kitchen. Hall. The front stairs.

She stopped on the third stair from the top. The one that creaks.

She stood on it for a long time.

Chapter 5 – Claire

Paid in Full

By Tuesday night we'd finished the rest of Dale's boiler list. The burner was clean, the relief valve and gauge replaced, and the flame stayed inside the boiler where it belonged. Hayes watched from the workbench while I checked it again.

Dale Sorensen passed the boiler on Wednesday at 2:06 p.m.

He stood in front of it for eleven minutes with his flashlight, and opened its little doors, and closed them, and read the pressure gauge, which now read what it was supposed to. Then he wrote one word on his clipboard and showed it to me, the way you'd show a child a report card.

PASS.

"Heat," said Dale. "Present."

"Thank you," I said. "Thank you so much. Really. Thank you."

Dale looked at me. Then he looked across the basement at Hayes, standing by the workbench in his cardigan, as far from the iron as the room allowed, with his hands folded.

"Allergy," said Dale, "noted." He went up the stairs. At the front door he stopped and looked up at the lion, which he photographed, and then he said, "You're welcome," and left. I've come to believe that's just how Dale says goodbye.

By Friday I had leases on both units. The first floor went to a night-shift nurse from the hospital on California Avenue named Fran, who asked only whether the radiators were loud, and when I said yes, said, "Good, I sleep better with company." The third floor went to a retired couple who taught high school chemistry for forty years and had opinions about the window sash. The bank got its paperwork. The loan officer said, "Congratulations, Ms. Briggs," again, in a different tone.

I had a house. It was warm. I had passed.

I've never been so unhappy in my life.

* * *

That's not true. I want to be fair to those two weeks. For two weeks I was happier than I've ever been, and that was the problem.

Here's how it went. I'd come home at 6:40 in the morning and leave a loaf on the kitchen table, and a note, and go to bed. While I slept, he worked. Dale's list was finished. Now he could get to the repairs the house had been waiting a hundred and thirteen years for: a crack in the plaster on the third floor that he said had been both-

ering him since the Coolidge administration, a pantry shelf, a window in the coach house nobody had looked out since 1958.

When I woke up at three, there'd be a note on the table, under the bread crumbs. In pencil. In copperplate.

The rye was excellent. The pumpernickel I'm still thinking about.

The third stair from the top would like you to stop stepping over it. It takes it personally.

There's a draft in your bedroom from the left sash. I've fixed it. Please walk past it as if it were always so.

I'm aware of you. —H.

And then from three in the afternoon until I left for work at nine-thirty, he couldn't work with me there watching him. So for six and a half hours every day, he was just there.

I'd never had anybody be just there.

He taught me the house. He'd stand in the hall and say, "Listen," and then the radiator in the front room would knock twice, and he'd say, "That's the front room. It does that at 4:15 because the sun goes off the bay window." He knew every sound it made. He knew which board in the dining room had been put in by the Novotnys after a fire in 1931, and which closet door Mrs. Healy had slammed so often in 1952 that it had a dent shaped like her hand. He told me about the Pikes and the Guttermans and the Jell-O. He told me about Agnes, who grew up and married a dentist in Oak Park and came back to see the house once, in 1971, at sixty-four, and stood on the front walk for a long time looking up at the lion, and then went away.

"Did she see you?" I said.

"She looked right at the window," said Hayes. "She was very old by then. Grown-ups don't."

I taught him to shape a loaf. That was allowed. At four in the afternoon, with flour on our hands and the radio on, we were baking together. The house had no claim on it. He was terrible at it. He was much too careful, and the loaves came out looking like they'd been designed by an architect, and he was ashamed of every single one and ate them anyway.

And he kissed me. In the kitchen with flour on his hands. In the hall by the third stair, which creaked. On the back porch in the cold with the coach house dark at the end of the yard and the city lit up orange behind it, where he could go and I couldn't stop him, as far as the end of the lot, and not one step farther.

He'd stop there. At the end of the lot. He'd stop, every time, the way you'd stop at the edge of a pool in the dark.

* * *

It was the second Tuesday after Dale passed the boiler when I opened the app.

I hadn't, in two weeks. I'd been avoiding it the way you avoid a bill on the counter. That night, on my break at Garland's, sitting on an overturned flour bucket by the back door with my phone, I opened IOU and scrolled through years of favors. Every ride. Every covered shift. The ladder in Albany Park. Ozzie, eleven times. Every one of them settled. Every one checked off.

I added a new line.

Hayes.

I sat on the flour bucket and looked at it for a long time.

Then I did the math. I'm not proud of it. I did it the way I'd do the yeast for a double batch. A hundred and thirteen years. Say forty hours a week, which is low, because he told me once the Guttermans had him going nearly every night. Fifty-two weeks. Illinois minimum wage, which I know, because I've been paid it.

It came out to a little over three and a half million dollars.

That was without the lion.

I sat by the back door of Garland Bakery at two in the morning with the radio going over the proofing cabinet and looked at a number I could never pay, not in a hundred lifetimes of rye. And under the number there was another one, smaller, that the app doesn't have a field for, and that I couldn't stop seeing.

He couldn't leave.

I'd been walking past that for two weeks, as if it were always so. He worked for me for bread, every day, because a house said so. He couldn't quit. He couldn't walk past the end of the lot. If I was awful to him, he'd still be there. If I was wonderful to him, he'd still be there. There was no version of my life in which Hayes was in my kitchen because he'd decided to be. He was in my kitchen because I owned the kitchen.

I've spent my whole life making sure nobody ever had to do anything for me they didn't choose to. I've paid back every ladder.

And I'd been kissing a man who wasn't allowed to say no to the house.

* * *

He knew something was wrong on Wednesday. He knows where I am in the house the way I know where my hands are. He knew I'd been standing at the kitchen window for twenty minutes.

He came in and stood next to me. He didn't say anything. He can wait for a hundred and thirteen years; twenty minutes doesn't bother him.

"I can't," I said.

He waited.

"Not while you can't leave. Not while you work for me for bread." I made myself look at him. "I can't be with someone who has to stay. It's not fair to you. It's not—You'd never know if you'd have picked me. Neither would I."

He was very still for a long time.

"I'd have picked you," he said.

"You can't know that."

"I've had a hundred and thirteen years of people to pick from, Claire."

"And you couldn't pick any of them," I said. "You got them. You got whoever bought the house." I put my hand flat on the window glass. It was cold. "Do you want to leave?"

He didn't answer. A man who knows every board in the house and the date it was laid stood in my kitchen, trying. He opened his mouth and closed it. He looked at the floor, and the window, and the wall over the stove where he goes when somebody's kind to him.

"I don't know," he said finally. "Nobody's ever asked what I want." A pause. "I don't think I'm built to."

* * *

I went to see Ida on Thursday. I brought a coffee cake.

She ate a corner of it with her eyes closed, as she'd done last time. Then she folded up her crossword and looked at me over her glasses.

"You want to free him," said Ida Fenner.

I hadn't said anything yet.

"I've had sixty years to think about every way that goes," she said. "It's all over your face, honey. You look like I looked in 1966." She put down the pen. "Then you'll lose him. You understand that? A house that gives clothes is a house that's done with you. He'll take that coat as his notice. They always do. They take it and they walk out the gate and they don't come back."

"Then he'll have left because he chose to," I said. "That's not the same as being kept."

Ida looked at me for a long time.

"No," she said. "No, it's not."

She looked out the window at the turned-off fountain. The aide came by with the cart and asked if we wanted juice, and Ida waved her off without looking.

"Six-foot-two," said Ida Fenner, quietly, to the window.

"What?"

"The doorframes. In that house. They're six-foot-two. Ray measured once, for a hat rack." She didn't look at me. "If you're going to do it, get a coat that fits him."

* * *

The coat came from a vintage shop on Milwaukee Avenue, three blocks south of Garland's, run by a woman with purple hair who has never once asked me why I come in.

It was charcoal wool, long, double-breasted, with horn buttons and a velvet collar gone soft at the edges, and a label inside from a tailor on State Street that went out of business before the First World War. It was a hundred and sixty dollars. I had less than five hundred in checking. I bought it in eleven minutes. I didn't enter it in the app.

I kept it in my bedroom closet in its garment bag for one more day. I didn't sleep much. I lay there Friday morning with my eyes open and listened to him working somewhere below me, a sash cord, a hinge, a long patient scrape like someone planing a door, and every sound went through me like a nail.

At three in the afternoon I got up, and took the coat out of the bag.

I didn't leave a loaf on the kitchen table. I left two. Rye and pumpernickel, the second bake, the good ones.

And I folded the coat over the back of the kitchen chair where he sits in the afternoons, the one by the window, with the velvet collar turned down neatly, the way you'd leave a coat for someone who was coming back for it. And on the table beside the bread, on a grocery bag, I wrote him a note.

I didn't write it in capitals. I wrote it small, so I wouldn't have to see it.

This isn't payment.

It's yours.

—*C.*

He was in the front room. He stayed out of the kitchen, and he never comes in while I'm in there in the afternoons unless I call him. I didn't call him.

I couldn't stay and watch him find it.

I put on my own coat at four and went to work five hours early. Ozzie looked at me when I came in the back door at five in the afternoon, in the middle of the day crew's cleanup, and didn't say anything. He just handed me an apron.

On the 56 on the way up Milwaukee I cried the whole way from Diversey to Belmont, in the back, by the window. The driver saw me in his mirror. At the Belmont stop he reached back over the partition without a word and handed me a little packet of tissues from his jacket.

I didn't thank him. It was the hardest thing I've ever done.

I just held the tissues, and looked out the window at the dark coming down early over Milwaukee Avenue, and thought about a man in a cardigan walking into my warm kitchen, the minute he felt me go out the front gate, and finding a coat on his chair.

Chapter 6 – Hayes

Request Line

I felt her go out the front gate at 4:01. I always feel it. Every person who has ever lived in this house, I've felt go out the gate, the way you feel a door close in another part of a building. It's a small thing. A little change in the weight of the house. Usually I go on with what I'm doing.

This time I went into the kitchen.

There were two loaves on the table. And a grocery bag, with her handwriting on it, small. And over the back of my chair, the one by the window, folded neatly with the collar turned down, there was a coat.

I knew what it was before I touched it. Every brownie knows. It's the first thing you know, before your own name. It's the shape of every story ever told about us, the one where the kind farmer's wife sews a little suit of clothes, and leaves it out by the hearth, and in the morning the brownie is gone.

I read the note.

This isn't payment.

It's yours.

I stood in the kitchen and read it eleven times. I tried to read it some other way. I've lived with this woman for a month, and I know she means every word she says, and I know she finishes what she starts, and I'd watched her stand at that window on Wednesday asking me what I wanted, and I hadn't been able to tell her. I'd given her nothing. And now here was her answer, folded over my chair.

A house that gives you clothes is a house that's done with you.

I'd never refused anything this house gave me. Not the saltines. Not the Jell-O. Not the crusts. I didn't know how. I don't think I'm built to.

So I put it on.

* * *

It fit.

It fit exactly, through the shoulders and down the arms, the hem just below my knees, as if somebody had stood in every doorway in the house and measured. The wool was heavy and warm. The velvet collar was soft against the back of my neck. It smelled faintly of a closet on Milwaukee Avenue and, underneath that, of her: caraway and flour and the soap she uses.

And then the house let go of me.

The nearest I can get to telling it is this: imagine you've been holding a hand for a hundred and thirteen years. You've held it so long you don't know it's a hand anymore.

It's just the shape your own hand makes. And then, very gently, without a word, somebody lets go.

The radiator in the front room, which I've heard every afternoon at 4:15 since 1948, knocked twice.

I didn't feel it. I only heard it.

I stood in the kitchen in the coat and I couldn't feel the third stair. I couldn't feel the sash cord on the third floor or the draft in the coach house or the mouse in the wall over the stove. I couldn't feel Fran downstairs, asleep before her shift. I couldn't feel where anybody was. I was a man standing in a kitchen, alone, with my two hands, and the house was just a house around me, and it was very, very quiet.

I didn't touch the bread. It wasn't wages anymore. I didn't know what it was.

I went down the front stairs. On the third from the top, I stopped, out of habit, and it creaked under my foot like any old board, and that was all.

The front door. The walk. The lion over my head, which I'd fixed for her, though it wasn't on the list.

The gate.

I put my hand on it. I've put my hand on that gate perhaps four thousand times, and every time it was the end of a sentence. I opened it. I stepped through.

The sentence kept going.

* * *

I walked all night.

I'd like to tell you I had a plan. I didn't. I walked because I could, and because every time I stopped I could feel how quiet it was where the house used to be.

I walked down Francisco to the boulevard. I'd seen the boulevard from the third-floor bay window every day for a hundred and thirteen years, the long double row of trees and the grass down the middle, and I'd never once stood on it. It's much wider than it looks from a window. Everything is. I walked along the grass in the middle with the cars going by on either side of me and their headlights on my coat, and I put my hand on the bark of an elm that I'd watched them plant in 1931, as a sapling, from the window. It was so big I couldn't reach around it.

I walked to the circle, where the column stands with the eagle on top. There was a couple on a bench at the foot of it, sharing one scarf between them, looking up at the eagle as if it might do something. I stood there for a long time and looked up with them. It didn't. They didn't seem to mind.

Around one in the morning, walking back up the boulevard, I met a coyote.

He came trotting down the grass median toward me from the north, a big gray-and-tan animal with a darker saddle down his back and an orange tag in his left ear, and when he saw me he stopped. We stood about ten feet apart, the two of us, on the boulevard under the streetlights. He looked at my coat. He looked at my face. He lifted his nose and took a long, careful breath of me, the way a man reads a letter twice.

Then he gave me a short, polite nod. I'd swear to it. The nod you'd give a colleague you'd passed on a stair. And

he went on down the median toward the river, and didn't look back.

I don't know what he was. I know that he knew what I was. It was the first time anybody had looked at me in the street and known, and I was so grateful to him I nearly said so out loud, to a coyote, on Logan Boulevard, and then I remembered that I could. Nobody's thanks could put me anywhere now. There was no wall to go into.

I didn't say it. I'd never learned how to say it to a stranger.

* * *

Milwaukee Avenue runs at an angle. It's the only street in that part of the city that does. I'd heard Mrs. Healy explain it once, in 1952, to her sister: it was an old trail, older than the grid, and they'd paved it where it was instead of where it ought to be. I walked up it. I didn't know why that way. I've thought about it since, and I believe it's because it was the way she went to work.

At a quarter to two I passed a brick building with a shuttered bank on the ground floor. The bank windows were dark and papered over. But the second floor was lit, one long window with a light on in it, and through the glass were the top of a microphone on a boom arm and a red ON AIR sign.

Across the street a little diner was dark, with a sign on the door: OPENS AT 5.

I stood on the sidewalk and looked up at that window for a long time.

I've had a kitchen radio on WDRY 1490 every night for eleven years, since Ida's son put it there for her company

and Ida, being Ida, never once changed the station. Polka till midnight. Then a woman with a voice like a lamp left on in another room, taking calls till sunrise, from people who couldn't sleep. And lately a man with her, a deep, old, formal voice that I never cared for, because he spoke like someone who'd been around for a very long time and wanted you to know it, and I'd been around a long time, too, and nobody ever let me say so.

I learned how people talk now from that window. I didn't know it was a window. I didn't know it was a place you could walk past.

* * *

I smelled the bread three blocks later.

Caraway. Rye. The second bake. It came down an alley off Milwaukee Avenue, warm and sour and dark, and I turned into the alley before I'd decided to, the way you'd turn your head at your own name. At the end of the alley there was a steel back door propped open with a milk crate to let the heat out of the ovens, and a yellow light, and a sound of a mixer going, and over that, on a radio somewhere inside, a woman's voice.

It was 2:13.

I stood in the alley in the dark, in her coat, outside the door, and I didn't go in. I couldn't think of a single reason she'd want me to. I was standing there trying to think of one when the radio played the ad.

The organ. The flat voice. *Przybylski and Sons Discount Cremation, serving Chicago's Northwest Side since 1952. Dust to dust. We'll take it from here.*

And then the lamp-in-another-room voice. "*Margo After Midnight, WDRY 1490. We've got a caller. You're on the air.*"

There was a pause.

"*Hi,*" said Claire.

I put my hand on the brick beside the door.

"*Hi. Sorry. Hi, Margo. I'm calling from work. My boss dialed. He said the line was open and he put the phone in my hand and he's standing here with his arms folded.*" A sniff. "*I'm sorry. I've never called a radio show.*"

"*Most people haven't,*" said Margo. "*Go ahead.*"

"*There's someone who— He does everything for me. Everything. He's done it for a long time. For other people, before me, for a very long time, and nobody ever paid him. And I'm not allowed to thank him. It's a rule. I can't explain it. If I thank him, it— He goes away.*" She took a breath. The mixer sounded behind her voice and through the door, a half second apart. "*So tonight I let him go. I did the thing that lets him go. And I keep thinking, I never got to thank him for his work and have him stay. Not once. And I wanted to ask. How do you thank somebody you're not allowed to thank?*"

There was a silence on the air. Margo didn't fill it.

"*Dennis?*" she said.

And the other voice came on. The old one. The one I'd never cared for. It came through the open door into the alley and filled it, deep and formal, like a voice that had been used in rooms with stone floors.

"*The last time I heard a woman ask about a debt in that voice,*" said Dennis, "*it was in Nineveh. Her family's well had been dug by a man who'd asked nothing for it, and she spent*

forty years trying to find a way to pay him, and he spent forty years refusing, and both of them thought that was the story." A pause. "*I can't tell you how to thank him. I can tell you what you want. I hear it. I can't lie about it.*"

"*Okay,*" said Claire, very small.

"*You don't want to thank him,*" said Dennis, to the whole Northwest Side of Chicago at 2:15 in the morning. "*Thanks is a receipt. It's how you close an account. You've been closing accounts your whole life.*" Another pause, long, the kind of pause a very old voice can afford. "*You want him to come home because he wants to. And you want to owe him for the rest of your life.*"

The alley was very quiet.

"*Huh,*" said Margo, on the air, after a while. "*Well. Hold that thought. Let's take a quick break.*"

* * *

I stood in the alley with my hand on the wall.

I'd been waiting all night for the house to tell me what to do. It's what I've always done. A hundred and thirteen years of a house telling me where everybody was and what needed fixing and when to stand still. And now there wasn't a house. There was an alley and a coat and a door, and nobody in the world could tell me whether to go through it.

She'd asked me what I wanted. I hadn't known.

I knew now. I'd been walking toward it all night up a crooked street.

I went in.

The good dry heat of ovens met me at the door. The room was bright, with flour on every surface. There was

an old man by the mixer in an apron with his arms folded, and he looked at me in the doorway, at the coat and the cardigan underneath it and the sleeve garters, and he didn't say anything at all. He just reached over and switched off the mixer.

She was at the bench with a telephone still in her hand. Her face was wet. She had flour up to her elbows and on her cheek and in her hair.

She turned around.

I don't know what my face did. I know what hers did. I'll keep it.

"You came back," said Claire.

"I don't know the rules for this," I said. "Nobody's ever done it." I looked down at the coat. "It fits."

"Ida told me. Six-two."

"You asked Ida."

"I asked Ida everything." She put the telephone down on the bench without looking at it, and it missed, and fell on the floor, and neither of us looked at that either. "You're not— Are you still— Can you feel the house?"

"No," I said. "It's very quiet."

"Does it hurt?"

"Yes," I said. "I'd like to come home anyway. If you'll have me. Not because it's the house. Because it's you."

She came around the bench. She stopped in front of me, close enough for the caraway to reach me, and she put both of her floury hands flat on the front of the coat, on the lapels, the way you'd check a loaf to see if it's done.

"I'm going to say it," she said. "I'm sorry. I have to. I've been holding it for a month."

"I know."

"If you go into a wall, I'll have Ozzie take the wall down."

Behind me, Ozzie, I'm told, nodded.

Claire took a breath.

"Thank you," she said. "Thank you for the faucet. And the cabinet door. And the bookcase out of the bookcase box. And *Sundries.* Thank you for the windows and the outlet and the tile from the coach house and the lion, which wasn't even on the list. Thank you for a hundred and thirteen years of saltines. Thank you for Ida. Thank you for the third stair. Thank you for the boiler, which you didn't touch, which I know, and which you did anyway." She was crying again, and laughing, and her hands were tight on my coat. "Thank you. Thank you so much. Thank you."

I stood there.

I stood in the back of Garland Bakery on Milwaukee Avenue at 2:20 in the morning in a charcoal coat, and I was thanked for my work, all the way through, every word of it, and I didn't go anywhere.

I opened my mouth, searching for an answer. A hundred and thirteen years and I'd never once had to answer. Nobody ever stayed long enough to hear it.

"Don't mention it," I said.

It was the only thing I knew. It came out of me the way *thank you* comes out of her.

Claire looked up at me with flour on her face.

"I'm going to mention it," she said. "Every day. For the rest of my life."

Behind us, very quietly, Ozzie switched the mixer back on.

Chapter 7 – Claire

Keeping House

Ozzie sent me home at five.

"Go," he said, and took the dough scraper out of my hand, the way he had the first week. "Take the handyman. Don't thank me."

"Thank you, Ozzie."

"Finally," said Ozzie, and turned his back on us to talk to the rye.

We walked out the back door into the alley at ten past five in the morning, and Hayes held the door for me, and then stood there holding it after I'd gone through, looking down at his own hand on it as if it belonged to somebody else. I understood. He'd held a thousand doors in my house. He'd never held one anywhere it didn't have to be.

"Where to?" I said.

He looked at me in the yellow light from the bakery, in my coat, with flour on his lapels where I'd grabbed him.

"Would you show me the lake?" he said.

* * *

The 77 Belmont runs east from Milwaukee Avenue all the way to the water. The first bus came at 5:31, almost empty, warm, with the heat blowing up from under the seats and the lights inside a sickly early-morning green. Hayes stood at the bottom of the steps for a second and looked at it the way he looks at the boiler.

"It's not iron," I said. "Mostly."

He got on.

I tapped my card for both of us. He sat by the window and didn't say anything for a long time. He watched Belmont Avenue go by, the dark storefronts and the bus shelters and the bare trees and the lit windows of people's kitchens, and every few blocks his hand would move a little on his knee, like he was still feeling for the house.

"Is it bad?" I said, quietly. "The quiet?"

"I keep reaching for the house," he said. "Like a step that isn't there."

I put my hand on his. I didn't say anything. I held on, and after a while his hand turned over under mine and held on back.

At the end of the line, at the lake, the driver said, "Last stop," and opened the doors, and we got up.

Hayes stopped beside the driver.

He stood there in the aisle in his charcoal coat, very straight, the way he stands at the bottom of the basement stairs, and gathered himself to speak. It took a while. The driver waited. I don't think the driver knew what he was waiting for.

"Thank you," said Hayes.

It came out a little too formal, like a man reading a word off a card in a language he scarcely spoke. The driver, who was about sixty and had been awake longer than either of us, looked up at him.

"No problem, man," said the driver. "Have a good one."

We got off. Hayes stood on the sidewalk at the end of Belmont Avenue with the bus pulling away behind him, and I'll never be able to describe his face properly. I've tried. The closest I can come is a loaf, the moment the crust splits in the oven and you see it's going to be all right.

"That's the first time I've ever said it to a stranger," he said.

"How was it?"

"Short," said Hayes, a little wonderingly. "I thought it would be longer."

* * *

We walked south along the lake path in the dark, a long way, past the harbor and the boats wrapped up for winter, until the rocks gave out and there was sand.

It was gray in that light. Gray and cold and packed hard, with a crust of frost on top that broke under our shoes, and old snow in the low places, and the lake beyond it black and flat and enormous, going all the way out to where the sky was just starting to come apart along the bottom in a thin line of orange.

Hayes stopped at the edge of the sand.

Then he knelt down, in his good coat, and took off his glove, and put his bare hand flat on the beach. He pressed down. He picked up a handful and let it run

through his fingers, slowly, the way you'd sift flour, and watched it fall.

"So that's where it comes from," he said.

I didn't say anything. I stood there behind him while the sun came up out of Lake Michigan, the first one he'd ever seen that wasn't through a window, and I let him have it.

When he stood up, he had sand on his knees and in the cuffs of his trousers, and I knew, I knew, that he'd sweep it up off my floor tomorrow and hold it in his hand for a minute before he threw it away.

"Claire," he said. "I've been thinking about what I want."

"You don't have to know yet."

"I know." He looked at the lake. "I'd like to keep house."

I kept hold of his hand.

"Not because it's the rule," he said. "There isn't a rule anymore. Because I'd like to. Because I'm good at it, and I like the work, and I like the third stair, and I'd like to be the one who knows which radiator knocks at a quarter past four." He turned and looked at me. "And I'd like to do it with you there, now. If that's all right. I'd like you to watch."

"It's all right."

"I'll want paying."

"You'll get paid."

"I don't mean bread." He paused. "I mean bread too."

I laughed. Out loud, on the beach at sunrise, with my face cold and my eyes wet. "Okay," I said. "We'll work it out. I'll put it in the app."

"Will you check it off?"

"No," I said. "Never."

* * *

We took the bus home. At the gate on Francisco Avenue he stopped, the way he'd stopped at the edge of the sand, and looked up at the lion.

"I can't feel it," he said. "Any of it."

So I took his hand, and walked him up the front walk, and told him.

"Fran's downstairs, asleep," I said. "She got in at seven-thirty. The chemistry teachers are on the third floor making oatmeal; you can smell it from the porch. The radiator in my front room's going to knock in about nine hours. And I'm right here."

He stood on the front steps and listened to me tell him where everybody in his house was, and his hand tightened in mine.

We went up the stairs together. On the third from the top, it creaked under me.

"That's me," I said.

"I know," said Hayes. "I'd know that anywhere."

At the top of the stairs, in my kitchen doorway, he stopped and took off the coat. He hung it on the hook by the door, beside mine, neatly, with the collar turned down, ready for the next time we went out.

Then I took his hand, and I took him to bed, and what happened after that, he says, is not work, and doesn't count, and I'm not putting it in the app.

Epilogue – Hayes

You're Welcome

On Sundays, Ida comes to dinner. She comes in a cab from Kedzie Gardens at four, in a good wool coat with her hair set, and the driver and I carry her up the front stairs in her chair, one step at a time, like a piece of furniture you're fond of. She makes us stop on the third from the top so she can hear it creak. Then she says, "Good," and we go on.

It's March now. The snow's gone off the boulevard. Fran's on nights at the hospital on California, and the radiators keep her company, and the chemistry teachers on the third floor have stopped having opinions about the window sash, because I fixed it while they watched, which I can do now. People watch me work all the time. Dale Sorensen sends me names. Neighbors on Francisco with sticking doors, a widower on Fairfield with a 1948 boiler he can't light. He writes them on the back of a citation in that blocky hand and leaves them in our mailbox

with a note: *Hayes (affiliated w/ house). Referral.* I bring Claire the iron jobs. She taps the knob twice. They pay me in money, now. I keep it in the Chock Full o'Nuts can. Claire keeps a line for me in her app, and every night she adds to it, and she has never once checked it off.

The first Sunday Ida came, in December, she sat at the kitchen table by the window in her chair and didn't look at me for a full hour.

She talked to Claire. She ate the pot roast. She told us both about the Cubs. Every time I brought her a glass of water, the bread, a saucer of milk she'd asked for out of habit, she looked at it and not at me, and her mouth went tight on the left side, where the callus is.

Then, at dessert, she put down her fork.

"All right," said Ida Fenner. "I'm ninety-one."

And she looked up.

She looked at me for a very long time. Up from the cardigan to the face, slowly, the way you'd read a letter you'd waited sixty years for and wanted to make last. I stood by the stove and let her. I'd never been looked at by her. I'd sat on the other side of a pantry door from her every night for sixty years and I'd never once seen her eyes, and they were a sharp brown, wet now.

"No beard," said Ida.

"No, ma'am."

"Ray had a beard. Briefly. In 1971. I made him take it off." She sniffed, and folded her napkin very precisely, and put it down. "You're taller than I pictured."

"I grew to fit the doorframes."

"Six-two," said Ida. "Ray measured." She looked at the pantry door, the old one, with the glass knob and the hook-and-eye latch. She looked at it for a while. Then she looked back at me.

"Thank you, Hayes," she said. "For sixty years. For listening. For Ray's boiler. For all of it." Her voice didn't shake at all. It was very steady, the way it was the night she told me about Ray, through the door. "I've been holding that since 1965. I've got a callus."

The kitchen was very quiet. In the front room, the radiator knocked twice, the way it does when the light goes off the bay window.

I stood at the stove. I didn't go anywhere. I've been thanked every day since November, by a woman who can't stop, for bread and boilers and the third stair and for nothing at all, for being in the kitchen when she comes home, and every time I've stood there and stayed and said the only thing I knew how to say. *Don't mention it.* I've said it so often Claire has started saying it back to me, just to annoy me.

But I'd been practicing a different reply. On the bus driver on Belmont. On Ozzie. On the coyote, once, in my head.

"Well?" said Ida. "Say it. I'm ninety-one."

Claire put her hand on mine on the edge of the stove. I could feel exactly where she was.

"You're welcome," I said.

Thank You for Reading

Thank you for joining the night crew, and for spending an hour on Francisco Avenue with Claire and Hayes.

If the radio on Claire's kitchen counter sounded familiar, that's because it is. WDRY 1490 is on all over After Dark in Chicago at 2:14 a.m., and every book in the series stands on its own.

If you enjoyed *Keeping House*, the kindest thing you can do is hit reply to my email and tell me which part made you laugh. I read every one.

More from After Dark in Chicago

Dead Air (After Dark in Chicago #1)

She has one wish. He has thirty nights.

A late-night radio host accidentally summons a demon during a discount cremation ad, and she puts him on the air. This is where Margo and Dennis begin.

[https://www.amazon.com/dp/B0HLY9PJB9]

Tagged Male (After Dark in Chicago #2)

She's scheduled to neuter him Monday. The full moon is Sunday.

An overnight ER vet, a coyote Animal Control keeps bringing back, and a naked man in Kennel 4 wearing her ear tag. (Yes, that coyote.)

[https://www.amazon.com/gp/product/B0HMGWNJTV]

Lake Effect (After Dark in Chicago #3)

Every time she falls a little harder, Chicago gets another six inches of snow.

A weather witch who doesn't do feelings, and the weekend weatherman who forecasts them.

[https://www.amazon.com/gp/product/B0HMQGWGZQ]

Coming next: *Standing Appointment* (After Dark in Chicago #4)

She's been his grandfather's best client for forty years. She's also been dead for all of them.

You're on the list, so you'll hear about it first.

About the Author

Tiffany Wayne writes witty, warm paranormal rom-coms with slow burns and guaranteed happy endings. She lives in Central Louisiana with her husband of twenty-five-plus years and five rescued cats. She gets her best ideas on long walks, and her favorite days are spent in pajamas with a good book.